

LEILA ESCOBAR-YOMONA

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Primate ecology and conservation in the Neotropics; seed dispersal by primates and its role in forest regeneration; primate responses to anthropogenic disturbance and habitat change; non-invasive physiological monitoring (stress physiology) applied to conservation and reintroduction.

EDUCATION

BSc in Biology (Bachiller)

Cayetano Heredia Peruvian University (UPCH), Lima, Peru · Completed Dec 2025

- Licentiate thesis in progress: seed dispersal by *Lagothrix flavicauda* and *Aotus miconax* in a montane cloud forest of Amazonas, Peru (second field season planned for Jan 2027).
- Full national undergraduate scholarship (Beca 18, Peruvian Ministry of Education).

Primate Research Course

Cocha Cashu Biological Station, Manu National Park — San Diego Zoo Wildlife Alliance Peru · Oct – Nov 2024

- Intensive residential training in Neotropical primate ecology, behaviour, field methods and research design, including round tables with Indigenous community members involved in primate conservation.

Research Experience for Peruvian Undergraduates (REPU) — Ecology cohort

Duke University, North Carolina, USA · 2024

- Competitive research placement in the Vilgalys Lab; fungal genomics research under the supervision of Dr. Lotus Lofgren (molecular laboratory work and open-access database development).

RESEARCH AND FIELD EXPERIENCE

Undergraduate Thesis Researcher

Neotropical Primate Conservation (NGO) & Lab of Socio-ecological Systems, UPCH — Amazonas, Peru · 2025 – present

- Designed and implemented a field study on seed dispersal patterns and rates of two endemic, threatened Peruvian primates, *Lagothrix flavicauda* and *Aotus miconax*, in montane cloud forest.
- Collected behavioural and ecological data through diurnal and nocturnal tracking, focal observations, feeding records and faecal sample collection for seed analysis.
- Coordinated fieldwork schedules, data management and logistics with local and international collaborators.

Consultant Biologist and Project Lead — Primate Reintroduction

Ikama Peru Wildlife Rescue Centre, Loreto, Peru · Jun 2026 – present

- Design and lead the ecological assessment of an Amazonian release site for primates rescued from the illegal wildlife trade, including woolly (*Lagothrix*) and howler (*Alouatta*) monkeys.
- Estimate primate abundance and density through standardised transect surveys; establish botanical plots to characterise vegetation composition, forest structure and food availability.
- Translate georeferenced field data into technical recommendations for the project and Peruvian authorities.

Volunteer — Golden Lion Tamarin Monitoring Programme

Associação Mico-Leão-Dourado (AMLD), Rio de Janeiro, Brazil (Atlantic Forest) · Jan – Feb 2026

- Monitored reintroduced *Leontopithecus rosalia* groups in a fragmented landscape through radio-telemetry, direct observation and tracking of individually identified animals.
- Assisted with supervised capture, vaccination, morphometric measurements and health assessments as part of long-term population monitoring.
- Worked in a Portuguese-speaking multidisciplinary team, also supporting environmental education with school groups.

Fellow — Independent Pilot Study

Cocha Cashu Biological Station, Manu National Park, Peru · Oct – Nov 2024

- Compared activity budgets and dietary preferences of lactating and non-lactating adult female *Ateles chamek* (22 focal follows); designed and applied an ethogram, collected ecological and non-invasive biological (faecal) samples, and analysed activity budgets and dietary overlap.

Field Assistant — *Ateles chamek* Population Monitoring

Amarakaeri Communal Reserve & SERNANP, Madre de Dios, Peru · Jul – Aug 2024

- Estimated relative abundance and population density of *Ateles chamek* in human-disturbed areas.

Volunteer — Department of Mammalogy

Natural History Museum, National University of San Marcos (UNMSM), Lima, Peru · Apr 2024 – Dec 2025

- Supported curation of the scientific mammal collections; contributed to the primate section of the updated list of the mammals of Peru, led by Dr. Víctor Pacheco.
- Coordinated primate talks and activities for public outreach events, including science fairs and Scientific Collections Day.

SCIENTIFIC PRESENTATIONS

- Activity patterns and dietary preferences in *Ateles chamek*: a comparative analysis between lactating and non-lactating females at Cocha Cashu, Peru. Poster, Peruvian Primatological Congress, Lima, 2026.
- Patterns and rates of seed dispersal by *Lagothrix flavicauda* and *Aotus miconax* in a montane forest of Amazonas, Peru. Oral presentation, 6th Undergraduate Scientific Congress, UPCH, Lima, 2025.
- Building an open-access database for *Suillus* fungi, a model genus for ectomycorrhizal ecology and evolution. Oral presentation, REPU Seminar, Lima, 2024.
- Introduction to the Study of Primates in Peru. Mini-course organiser and speaker, Natural History Museum, National University of San Marcos, Lima, 2025.

SKILLS

Field methods: focal and scan sampling; ethogram design; activity budgets; feeding records; diurnal and nocturnal tracking; radio-telemetry; individual identification; line-transect abundance and density surveys; botanical plots; reintroduction site assessment.

Animal and sample handling: supervised primate capture and handling; morphometrics; assistance with vaccination and health assessments; non-invasive faecal sample collection, labelling and traceability.

Data and laboratory: R (data wrangling, basic statistics, diversity and similarity indices); QGIS and georeferenced data; Excel; DNA extraction; PCR and nested PCR; agarose gel electrophoresis; aseptic technique; MAFFT, ClustalX; introductory MrBayes and BEAST.

Languages: Spanish (native); English (advanced — full ICPNA programme 2019–2023 and research placement in the USA); Portuguese (intermediate).

LEADERSHIP AND SCIENTIFIC ENGAGEMENT

Americas Representative, Student Affairs Leadership Team

International Primatological Society (IPS) · 2026 – present

Communications Team Volunteer

Latin American Society of Primatology (SLAPrim) · 2025 – present

- Co-organised a region-wide campaign against keeping primates as pets; contributing to a primate guide for the December 2026 Latin American congress.

President (2025); Founder-Coordinator, Primatology Division (2026 – present)

Ecology, Evolution and Conservation Student Group (GEECO), UPCH · member since 2021

- Founded the group's first primatology division (the first at a Peruvian university), including a bilingual (Spanish–English) International Primate Day webinar series for students and recent graduates; organised EcoLink 2025, the group's first in-person ecology and conservation symposium; co-organised the 2025 Peruvian Primate Week.

Research Secretary

Association of Heredian Students of Science (AECH), UPCH · 2024

- Founded the “Semillas Científicas” research mentorship programme for first-year students; co-organised the 5th Heredian Scientific Congress.

Co-coordinator, Projects Commission

Voices for the Future Peru (Fridays for Future Peru) · 2025 – present

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

International Primatological Society · American Society of Primatologists · Latin American Society of Primatology (SLAPrim) · Peruvian Primatological Association · Society for Conservation Biology